

English Standard

HSC Exams 2019 – 2024

Common Module Section 1

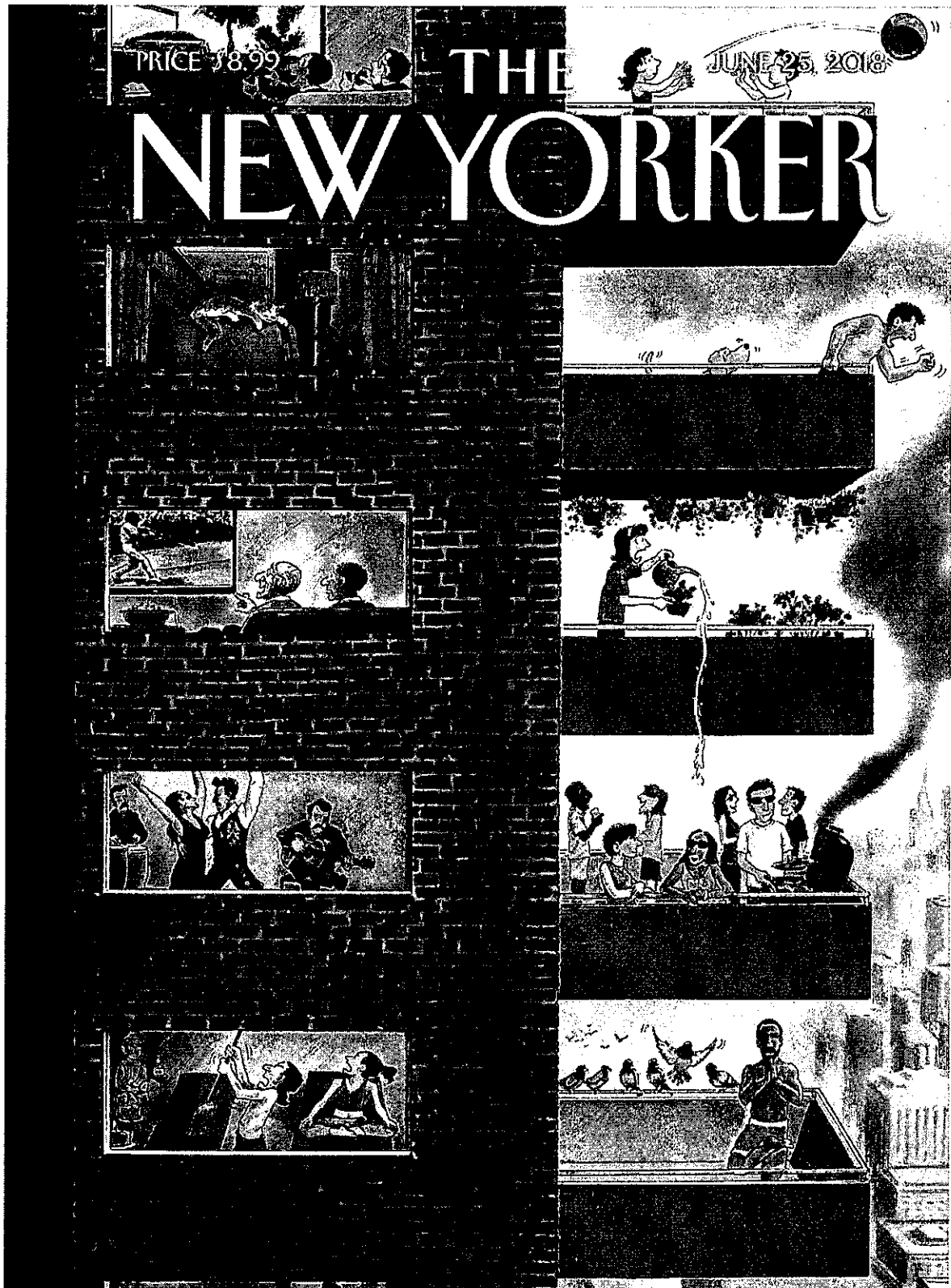
Short Answer

Texts

2019

Section I

Text 1 — Magazine cover



Cover 'City Living', June 25th, 2018 issue of *The New Yorker*
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Text 2 — Poem

The Red Sweater

slides down into my body, soft
lambs wool, what everybody
in school is wearing, and for me
to have it my mother worked twenty
hours at the fast-food joint.
The sweater fits like a lover,
sleeves snug, thin on the waist.
As I run my fingers through the knit,
I see my mother over the hot oil in the fryers
dipping a strainer full of stringed potatoes.
In a twenty hour period my mother waits
on hundreds of customers: she pushes
each order under ninety seconds, slaps
the refried beans she mashed during prep time,
the lull before rush hours, onto steamed tortillas,
the room's pressing heat melting her make-up.
Every clean strand of weave becomes a question.
How many burritos can one make in a continuous day?
How many pounds of onions, lettuce and tomatoes
pass through the slicer? How do her wrists
sustain the scraping, lifting and flipping
of meat patties? And twenty

hours are merely links
in the chain of days startlingly similar,
that begin in the blue morning with my mother
putting on her polyester uniform, which,
even when it's newly-washed, smells
of mashed beans and cooked ground beef.

JOSEPH O LEGASPI

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Text 3 — Poem

Boomerangs in a Thunderstorm

For Uncle Steve

The clouds are so low that I imagine a puffy hand, reaching out and sending a boomerang off-course. But here we are, like it should be, an uncle and his nephew, throwing boomerangs, tuning the wind. Thunder cracking. Whooping shapes dance across the overcast sky. My lungs are full of the spirits of rain, and it is not long before we are both soaked, riding the storm. Our boomerangs scale the breeze ... you should always throw a 'returning' boomerang into the wind ... like a sail. On the summit of the sacred owl mountain, *Coot-tha Dreaming*, throwing boomerangs in a thunderstorm.

*The unsettled leaf
spirals to a soaked ground,
rain disguised tears*

SAMUEL WAGAN WATSON

Watson, Samuel Wagan, *Love Poems and Death Threats*, St Lucia: UQP, 2014
'Boomerang in a Thunderstorm'
Reproduced with permission from Queensland University Press

Text 4 — Prose fiction extract

Dorahy submits to this pull of fate.

He packs a small bag, noting how one's needs in age lie in inverse ratio to the expansion of the soul.

He hopes. He boards a lumbering coastal vessel that rocks him out of his capital and, after a sea-shaken slumber, wakes after the third night to a sugarville morning of hard blue and yellow north of the tropic. From the salty deck he observes the wide reaches of blue bay water as the boat enters his destiny. Coastal scrub has thinned out its scraggy imprecision and has become the scaggier, scrubrier buildings of a town he has not entered for twenty years, which yet, as he watches the houses grow larger with approach, fills him with a nauseating nostalgia.

He has kept apart as far as possible from the other passengers all the week, but now, as they join him along the railing, he feels obliged to share the excitement and the chatter. Hands point. Voices cry out. The boat noses its rusty way from harbour to river and river docks.

There are only two others disembarking and he hopes to avoid them, knowing the town is full of pubs. Their reason for return is the same as his and already, conscious of his ambitions for solitariness, he wonders why he has come. His elderly legs wobble on this Friday morning gangplank but they are the same legs that strolled through this town twenty years before, and he marvels that he is experiencing grief when, he supposes, rage would be the better thing. Turning his back firmly on the river and the docks, he walks steadily up the slope past the warehouses and enters the town.

The streets are busy with horses and big drays*. There are people on bicycles bumping along the rough roads. Groggy from all this, he stands uncertain in sunlight, his bag at his feet. One should never go back. He decides this with vehemence and wonders then is he thinking of the psychic mistake of it or his own lack of charity. One does go back, he knows, again and again. One should forgive places as much as people.

This place has much to be forgiven it.

Terrible to sense the valetudinarian** legs tentative along the footpath. But up here everyone saunters. He is relieved he does not look remarkable. It is a refusal to fight the heat which already is dealing him blow upon blow; rather a yielding to it. Already steam is rising from the baking township and its slow river. Already there is sweat along his hairline, the saddened back of his neck, trickling between his breasts.

Text 4 continues on page 6

Text 4 (continued)

He feels reluctant to face his hotel yet, knowing its drabness already, the tired pots of fern, the bar-stink, the narrow bedroom with its spotted mirror. He walks on one hundred, two hundred yards and finds a tea-shop sluicing out the evening before. Rinsing the last strains of it, a thin girl has been doing penance with mop and bucket. She couldn't care less about this elderly man with his thin face and thinner voice demanding tea. She isn't forgiving anybody, refuses the credit of his smile, while slinging her bile across one table surface after the other with a rancid grey rag.

But he tries.

'It's twenty years,' he volunteers, 'since I've been here.' (Where are the banners, the bunting ...)

She deals savagely with the counter and crashes the glass jars of sweets to one side.

'Lucky you,' she says.

THEA ASTLEY
Extract from *A Kindness Cup*

* drays	<i>horse-drawn carts</i>
** valetudinarian	<i>weak, feeble</i>

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End of Text 4

Section I

Text 1 — Feature article extract

Look Alive

I WAS WALKING down the street the other day and I met a very small child. I was chatting with the child's parent – a friend of mine – who had stopped me as I dashed past, and we were doing the thing where we had to move our conversation off the footpath so other people could pass. I realised, after a while, that I had not yet properly engaged with the little girl, so I asked her a question, which she answered in that way children have sometimes when speaking to adults as if to say: *I will indulge your frankly dull question with an answer, but mostly I shall watch your face with a look of mild disdain.* I thought perhaps this would be the end of it but then she asked me something. 'Pardon?' I asked her and watched a slight look of irritation cross her face. 'I said,' she shouted up at me, 'are you on the way to somewhere?'

We are always but not really on our way to somewhere. Look back at any letter, email or message thread from a friend when you were updating them on your life and you will discover you were on your way somewhere but you were also exactly where you are now. Perhaps, then, the secret is to be watching, always, the things that you're seeing at the moment, enjoying them for what they are, rather than second-guessing what they might become. Small people (even the intense wizard I met in the street) are

very good at this. They run into a field and find hiding places, cubbies, swords and forts. They forget about time and place and social mores*. So look around.

* * *

Find the best thing and the worst thing and the thing you would find the hardest to explain to an alien ...

Find the best view.

Can't find a view? Tidy a desk. Wash a window. Rearrange a cutlery drawer ...

Sometimes, where you are right now isn't very nice at all. Sometimes it's hard and sad and confusing and frustrating. On those days: find a thing. Doesn't have to be a big thing. Doesn't even have to be a thing you care about, but there is always something. A person being nice to someone in a supermarket. A song that takes you somewhere else. A doughnut. A bath. Toast.

This is a Public Service Announcement: doesn't matter where you're going, or what happens next. There's always toast ... and a nice tidy desk.

LORIN CLARKE

* mores

customs of a society or community

Text 2 — Prose fiction extract

The Movie People

When the movie people left, the town grew sad. An air of disaster lingered in the stunned streets ...

There was something shameful to it, like defeated virtue, and also something confidential, because people were so in need of consolation they turned to each other with all their private burdens of ecstasy and despair. There was at that time a run of extraordinary weather – as if the blank blue sky, the unshaded sun and the minor, pleasurable breeze had all been arranged by the movie people. The weather lasted for the duration of the filming and then began to turn, so that within a few weeks of the close of production, a stiff, mineral wind had swept television aerials from roofs and disorganised the fragile root systems of more recently imported shrubbery.

My main sense of this time is as a period of collective mourning in which the townspeople began to wear the clothes they had adopted as film extras and meet disconsolately on street corners to re-enact their past happiness. I didn't participate. I was happy the movie people had left. I was overjoyed, in fact, to see no more trucks in the streets, no more catering vans in the supermarket parking lot, no more microphones and boom lights standing in frail forests on corners or outside the town hall. The main street of town had been closed to traffic for the filming, and now the townspeople were reluctant to open it again. It's a broad street lined with trees and old fashioned gas lights (subtly electrified) and those slim, prudish, Victorian storefronts that huddle graciously together like people in church, and as I rode down the street on my scooter on those windy days after the movie people left, it struck me as looking more than ever like the picturesque period town, frozen in the nineteenth century, that brought the movie to us in the first place.

I rode my scooter to the disgust of women in crinolines* with their hair braided and looped; men in waistcoats and top hats; citizens of some elderly republic that had been given an unexpected opportunity to sun itself in the wan** light of the twenty-first century. I knew these people as butchers, plumbers, city commuters, waterers of thirsty lawns, walkers of imbecile dogs, washers of cars, postmen, and all the women who had ever taught me in school. They were so bereft*** that they stayed in the street all day. They eddied and flocked. Up the street, and then down again, as if they were following the same deep and certain instinct that drives herring through the North Sea. They consulted fob watches and pressed handkerchiefs to their sorrowful breasts. The wind blew out their hooped skirts and rolled the last of the plastic recycling bins down the street and out into the countryside, where they nestled lifelessly together in the scrub.

FIONA MCFARLANE

* crinolines *long dresses with hoops in the skirts*
** wan *pale, weak*
*** bereft *a feeling of loss*

Text 3 — Internet article

From On Writing: authors reveal the secrets of their craft

Ideas for things come into one's head, or bits of ideas; you feel there's something – there's some meat on the bone, there's something there that lures you on. The more you think about it the more you're led into this new world and the more of that world you see. And part of having an idea is having some notion of how you would tell the story ... and the idea for the way to tell the story helps you to see what the story is. The story suggests the means, the means suggests the story; it's mutually dependent. And you don't have very much choice in the matter. Ideas come, characters suggest themselves, and the nature of the story and the nature of the characters dictates how it's going to be done.

I suppose if people are not writers or painters or whatever they see the life of the artist as being one of great freedom, but it's not really; it's as constrained as anyone else's by the material that's available. The thing seems to have some kind of reality in one's head; it seems to be something that one is discovering, rather than inventing. I see that as a kind of psychological trick on oneself, because the whole point about fiction is that it's invention. It doesn't really seem like it at the time – it seems as if you are slowly discovering something that already exists and seeing how the different parts of it relate to each other.

MICHAEL FRAYN

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Text 4 — Illustration



Illustration By Julie Paschkis, from *Sea of Words*

Text 5 — Poem

It Begins with Darkness

People file into the room, find their seats,
fill up the air with chatter. The stage
is bare except for a leather couch
and a lamp on a chrome and bakelite* stand.
It's meant to be an old factory converted
to an apartment – exposed pipes, a ceiling
fit for a cathedral, polished oak floorboards.
A man dressed in black makes an announcement
about mobile phones. The lights go down.
I don't know what I'm doing here,
I just know that this is theatre, my son an actor.

I hear his voice before I see him. It's as loud
as the wind swatting at a loose sheet of corrugated iron
on the chook shed. When he comes on stage
he swears five times in the first minute,
all in the presence of a lady. I've a good mind
to go down and slap him about the face,
except that I'm sitting right in the middle of the row
and it wouldn't be easy getting past all those knees.
Then I remember that he's pretending
to be someone else, that this is his job now.
Soon everyone is laughing – they're smiling
and nodding and taking in every move my son makes.

Text 5 continues on page 7

Text 5 (continued)

I've never been to a play before. It's not
boilermaking, not the flying sparks from an arc welder**,
not the precision required for a submarine hull,
nor the relief of taking off your helmet,
gloves and apron and enjoying the coolness
of a harbour breeze as you eat your lunch
but it is, I guess, a different kind of trade.
I watch more and it all happens before my eyes
and I can see that he loves this lady,
everyone can see it and I want to say, 'Son,
what are you afraid of?' I want to reach out
and lift him up as I did when he was two
years old, riding a supermarket trolley
and screaming as if he'd just discovered
the power of his lungs. But I can't touch him now
or even talk to him and I have this feeling
that it will turn out badly, like the week you have
the numbers in Lotto, but forget to buy the ticket.

The stage is dark again and he's not swearing now
and the lady's really pleased to see him
and she burns this scrap of paper and it flares up,
bright and yellow in the darkness
and the flame flickers across his forehead
and I glimpse in my son's face the unmistakable
features of my father who is ten years dead.
Although the three of us won't ever meet again,
I'm sure Dad would have loved this – a story
that takes a whole evening in the telling
and a small fire that leaps and glows
and transfixes us, for as long as it burns.

ANDY KISSANE

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* bakelite *an early form of plastic used to make electrical equipment*
** arc welder *arc welding is a process that is used to join metal to metal*

End of Text 5

Text 1 — Feature article extract**Aboriginal astrophysicist proves anyone can aim for the stars**

For Karlie Noon, the sky tells a story.

When the Gamilaraay woman looks at the moon, she sees more than just a bright orb. A surrounding halo hints that a storm is coming. The halo's size bears clues about the movements of the clouds. If the stars are hidden, rain is imminent.

She has gleaned this knowledge from a combination of traditional Aboriginal stories passed down by her elders, and a decade of scientific study.

"Observing the stars, observing the sky, observing the land – these are things that my ancestors have been doing forever," Ms Noon said.

The 30-year-old was the first Aboriginal woman to complete a dual degree in maths and physics, before furthering her studies in astronomy and astrophysics.

She has just been named the Sydney Observatory's first astronomy ambassador. "It's honestly a girl's dream job," Ms Noon said.

Such achievements were once unimaginable for Ms Noon, who grew up in social housing near Tamworth and dropped out of school in year 8.

As a child, she had never enjoyed school. No one in her family had finished high school and education wasn't considered that important.

When she left school Ms Noon began weekly tutoring lessons with an Aboriginal elder, during which she was surprised to rekindle her innate love of maths.

"I was able to disconnect learning from school and see them as separate things," she said.

By the following year, she was doing maths at a year 12 level. With some convincing, after a few years at TAFE, she returned to school in year 10 and never looked back.

Ms Noon was drawn to astronomy due to its better, but still imperfect, gender balance and because it presented an opportunity to explore the scientific knowledge embedded within Indigenous culture and traditions.

She sees her role at the Sydney Observatory as a platform to share her love of space and science with a wider audience. But she also wants people to know that if a tattooed, proud Aboriginal woman has defied the odds to excel in a scientific field, anyone can do it.

ELLA ARCHIBALD-BINGE

Text 2 — Prose fiction extract

A brilliant summer's day up the coast.

Fresh eyes scoped the entirety of the ocean. Home to one too many a beach memory. Nine-year-old me yearned for that salty tang of the sea breeze. I watched as my younger brother David clambered out of the car. We did most things together. Wearing colourful bathers, we raced to an empty shade-cloth area as Mum yelled, 'Quick! Before we lose it!' as a line of cars pulled up a distance away. We anchored ourselves in cool sand and waited for Mum and Dad to come.

Fiddling with broken sticks, a crab scuttled past. A teeny one. Its home inches away from my feet. Curiosity got the best of me, I moved closer. David straightened up.

'Where're you goin'?'

'Nowhere!' I said.

I shuffled closer to the hole, hoping to hide the entrance from him. David had a thing for crawling things. Lizards, insects, little mice ... if it had four or more legs, David found it like hens to grain.

The crashing of waves along the rocky coastline shifted my train of thought. Not far from where we were situated were the Blowholes: a mysterious spot where danger and beauty are one and the same. As if she had read my mind, Mum announces we're off for a walk over there. I always enjoyed the spectacle of it. The big *whooshing* of the water as it rushed up from below, as if some supernatural force was behind it. The build-up of sticky tension from the anticipation of something magnificent about to unfold, followed by the explosion of a million insignificant splashes. This was something that was witnessed from a distance.

As we made our way cautiously over to the cliff's edge, I sensed my brother's hesitance. His face was a mixture of stifled fear and pure excitement.

'Are we *reeeally* gonna go right up?' David says.

'Yeah, we are.' I say back. 'Even better! Let's see who can stay right up at the edge for the longest!!'

Having known seven-year-old David, the opportunity was a given. The phrase *Wouldn't miss it for the world* in capital letters could've been a flashing neon sign on his forehead at that given moment. And we were off.

Rumbling from deep below, the feeling of promised unease filled us from the toes up. The feeling was similar to the monster underneath your bed – the unknown consuming you much more than the risk of physical harm. We both stood side by side like dolls in the shopfront, out for display ... The air shifted, and a niggling thought crossed my mind. As I looked down, there was no water.

I could see a teeny crab, wedged between two crevices. It was so similar to the one back on the beach.

I should've known better than to stand that close ... It was too close.

NANCY MURRAY
Extract from *Coast*

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Text 3 — Nonfiction extract

New books find their way to us via a number of routes. Most obvious is bricks-and-mortar store browsing. There we are, in a shop, reading the back cover, brushing fingers over embossed titles, handling and patting, appreciating the book as an object. We can tickle spines and open up to brush pages, and – if no one's looking – devour their smell. If everything chimes then the book is placed in a wrestler's headlock, claimed as a joey kangaroo in its mother's pouch. Chances are that it will soon have siblings – our eyes are bigger than our bedside tables.

Or perhaps a new book may be fostered from a library or foisted* upon you by a friend who insists you will appreciate it. On the way home, blurbs are again consumed, and other furnishings idly absorbed – the review quote and the About the Author, the writer dedication and the font declaration.

Then there is that saintly thud of an online order plummeting from the letterbox, or the luscious scrape of cardboard on floor as, on returning home, you push the front door against the package. To buy online leaves you blind in comparison with bookshop scrutiny, but the gamble is surely worth the prize of feverishly setting about unwrapping the parcel. We are Charlie Bucket unwrapping a Wonka Bar, and there is a golden-ticket feeling every time.

By whichever route a book finds us, in our hands we now hold, we hope, a future escape.

DANIEL GRAY

Extract from *Scribbles in the Margin*

© Daniel Gray, 2017, *Scribbles in the Margins: 50 Eternal Delights of Books*,
Bloomsbury Publishing Plc

* foisted *imposed*

Text 4 — Poem

**For B, at Plaza Blanca, New Mexico*,
having known each other three days.**

*Here, you said, this is a piece of quartz.
Take it, and close your hand around it.*

The rock was heavy for something so small. Its rough
edges pressed my outline, changed my shape in a small way.

I turned it over. I closed my hand around it.
The rock made me think of difficult work

like lowering yourself into a bath. The quartz made me think
of the enormous past, a vast plateau, on which the present moment holds still—

full and complete. I looked around. We were wrapped in the loose embrace
of the ground, and the bare trees, and the low-slung clouds. The rock

is ancient. The white formations of *Plaza Blanca* are ancient, as sleep is ancient—
and our young lives are winks in a deep night, wrinkles

on a long green sea. The sea is more alien than the moon to that white place. You
smiled. You smiled as if to say *we are two odd birds, aren't we?*

I unclosed my hand
and the quartz bloomed there—

CHARLOTTE GUEST

With kind permission of Charlotte Guest / AP Anthology

* Plaza Blanca, New Mexico *'Plaza Blanca' translates from the Spanish as 'the white place'.
It is a region that is famous for large white limestone formations.*

Text 5 — Prose fiction extract

With Lan, one of my tasks was to take a pair of tweezers and pluck, one by one, the grey hairs from her head. “The snow in my hair,” she explained, “it makes my head itch. Will you pluck my itchy hairs, Little Dog? The snow is rooting into me.” She slid a pair of tweezers between my fingers, “Make Grandma young today, okay?” she said real quiet, grinning.

For this work I was paid in stories. After positioning her head under the window’s light, I would kneel on a pillow behind her, the tweezers ready in my grip. She would start to talk, her tone dropping an octave, drifting deep into a narrative. Mostly, as was her way, she rambled, the tales cycling one after another. They spiraled out from her mind only to return the next week with the same introduction: “Now this one, Little Dog, this one will really take you out. You ready? Are you even interested in what I’m saying? Good. Because I never lie.” A familiar story would follow, punctuated with the same dramatic pauses and inflections during moments of suspense or crucial turns. I’d mouth along with the sentences, as if watching a film for the umpteenth time—a movie made by Lan’s words and animated by my imagination. In this way, we collaborated.

As I plucked, the blank walls around us did not so much fill with fantastical landscapes as open into them, the plaster disintegrating to reveal the past behind it. Scenes from the war, mythologies of manlike monkeys, of ancient ghost catchers from the hills of Da Lat* who were paid in jugs of rice wine, who traveled through villages with packs of wild dogs and spells written on palm leaves to dispel evil spirits.

OCEAN VUONG

Extract from *On Earth We’re Briefly Gorgeous*

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* Da Lat *a city in Vietnam*

Text 1 — Prose fiction extract

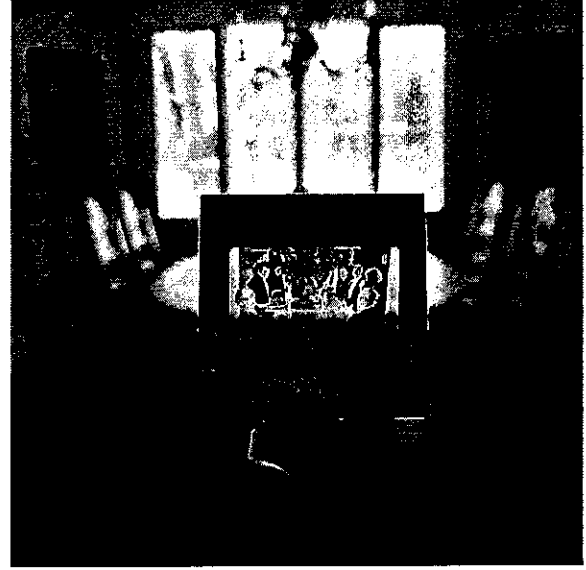
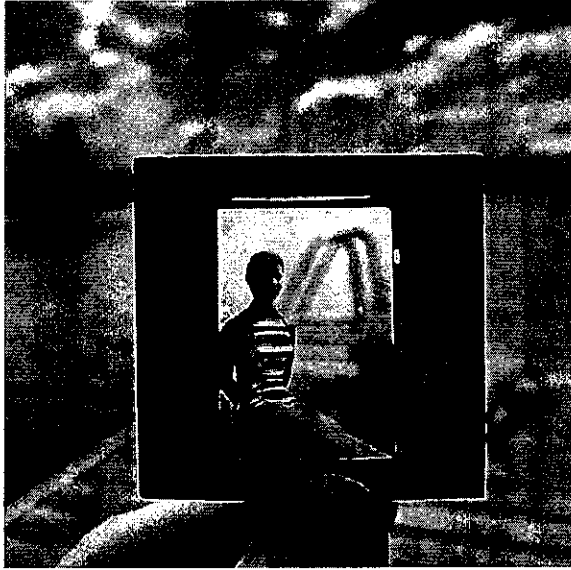
Travelling by train was different, for even if there were occasional delays and breakdowns there was never any traffic on train rides, no effort or strain required as you were borne smoothly and inexorably* toward your goal. Looking out at the silhouettes of the city passing by in the darkness, Krishnan thought of all the hours he'd spent on trains during his time in India, when he was on holiday from university and had the chance to leave Delhi, to see other parts of that vast, seemingly endless country. He'd spent most of those journeys sitting or lying on his seat or berth, reading, listening to music, or simply looking out at the small, unpeopled rural stations, the hot wind rushing into the carriage through the open doors and windows, allowing him to breathe in the air of the places they passed and absorb their smells, as if he were in some kind of communion with these small towns and villages as they flitted by. The constant movement of wind through the carriage would feel like a calling to him from outside, and leaving his seat he would go down every so often to the linking section between carriages, where standing in a corner he would look to make sure nobody was watching ... and pull open one of the heavy train doors, one hand tightly clasping the grip on the door frame so he didn't fall into the passing landscape ... The warm, fragrant air of the countryside buffeting his face, he would look out at the wide expanses of farmland, brush, and forest, at the plains that went by for sometimes hours at a stretch without stopping, and he felt, at such moments, something close to a sense of liberation, if not quite liberation then the sense of at least being on the verge of liberation.

ANUK ARUDPRAGASAM
A Passage North

* inexorably *in a way that is impossible to stop*

no memory is ever alone

new york photographer catherine panebianco
blurs the lines between past and present.



Frankie Magazine Issue #100, March/April 2021. Photographer - Catherine Panebianco

Hi Catherine! Tell us about your series, No Memory is Ever Alone. My dad has shown these slides every Christmas I can remember – the photos were taken from when he was 15 to about 25. He'll bring out the old projector and screen, we'll get the popcorn, and we'll gather around to watch the slideshow and hear the stories. It's a family tradition.

My series started in 2016. My mum had the slides out, organising things, and I was doing an Instagram project based on a word or phrase for the day. That day was 'from where I stand'. I saw a slide of my mum in a boat at Newboro Lake in Canada – where our family has gone each summer for years – and thought, maybe I can do something with this at Chautauqua Lake, where I

live now. I took it down there and tried hundreds of photos until I saw the backgrounds line up. I knew I had something and started trying other slides in my present environment. The past intertwined with the present.

What kinds of moments are featured in your dad's slides? They're everyday moments. He was just learning photography, so he took photos of his everyday life. I've placed his slides in my everyday life, too, to represent our day-to-day happenings: weddings, road trips, family and relationship moments. It's created a trail of memories, each of which has its own association for both of us ...

Have you learnt anything while putting this project

together? I've learnt it's so important for families to take and keep photographs. If my dad hadn't done this 60 years ago, I wouldn't have had all these memories – or more importantly, a visual representation of our memories. I worry that people aren't printing photos of their family life. What will happen 50 years from now – will those memories from our iPhones and Instagram be there for future generations?

I also learnt that these photos are my family, but they're also every family. We all have traditions – they may look different, but we all have them. People often tell me the photos spark a memory from their own family, and that makes me really happy. It's important to remember that we're a lot more alike than we are different.

Text 3 — Poem

Nine Spice Mix

First they tango on my tongue,
nimble couples careening*,
then together
form an Arab-style line dance
stepping, stomping, swaying.

West Indies allspice dazzles,
berries tangling with cinnamon sticks,
while cloves, Indonesian natives,
lead with a spirited solidarity solo.

Coriander seeds offer greetings in Hindi
as others toast comrades in languages
beyond borders and blockades.

Lifting up sisterhood, sun-wizened nutmeg
starts a sibling dance with mace.
Cumin demurs**, then surprises
with subtle exultation***.

Queen of spices cardamom,
host of the party, gives a nod to flavors
in hiding: lemony, sweet, warm,
fragrant, nutty, pungent, hot.

Encouraged, feisty black peppercorns
shimmy center stage, organizing
the unique union of nine
for a vivacious global salute.

ZEINA AZZAM

* careening	<i>moving quickly and uncontrollably</i>
** demurs	<i>hesitates</i>
*** exultation	<i>feeling of great joy</i>

Text 4 — Prose fiction extract

I was in a long, dark, wood-panelled corridor lined with bookshelves that reached from the richly carpeted floor to the vaulted ceiling. The carpet was elegantly patterned and the ceiling was decorated with rich mouldings that depicted scenes from the classics, each cornice supporting the marble bust of an author. High above me, spaced at regular intervals, were finely decorated circular apertures through which light gained entry and reflected off the polished wood, reinforcing the serious mood of the library. Running down the centre of the corridor was a long row of reading tables, each with a green-shaded brass lamp. The library appeared endless; in both directions the corridor vanished into darkness with no definable end. But this wasn't important. Describing the library would be like going to see a Turner* and commenting on the frame. On all the walls, end after end, shelf after shelf, were *books*. Hundreds, thousands, millions of books. Hardbacks, paperbacks, leather-bound volumes, uncorrected proofs, handwritten manuscripts, *everything*. I stepped closer and rested my fingertips lightly on the pristine volumes. They felt warm to the touch, so I leaned closer and pressed my ear to the spines. I could hear a distant hum, the rumble of machinery, people talking, traffic, seagulls, laughter, waves on rocks, wind in the winter branches of trees, distant thunder, heavy rain, children playing, a blacksmith's hammer – a million sounds all happening together. And then, in a revelatory moment, the clouds slid back from my mind and a crystal-clear understanding of the very nature of books shone upon me. They weren't just collections of words arranged neatly on a page to give the *impression* of reality – each of these volumes *was* reality. The similarity of these books to the copies I had read back home was no more than the similarity a photograph has to its subject – these books were *alive*!

JASPER FFORDE

Lost in a Good Book

Lost in a good book by Jasper Fford. Reproduced with permission of the Licensor through PLSclear.

* Turner *a famous painter*

A line in the snow

ANTARCTICA'S PRESERVATION HAS BEEN A GLORIOUS FEAT – LET'S KEEP THE CONTINENT THIS WAY

At the end of our world there's a wonderland that has an innocence to it, a purity, that feels fragile and spiritual. This extraordinary region is relatively untouched. It's a region that demonstrates humanity at its best; for that pesky, rapacious* species known as human has actually left this place largely alone except in the noble, light-touch pursuit of scientific inquiry. This gentleman's agreement is honourable and altruistic** – astonishingly so, in this day and age – and has been respected for 60-odd years. But how much longer can this arrangement be preserved?

I'm talking about Antarctica, of course. The vast continent that's a barometer of human goodness. It shows us that wealthy nations can act with consensus and without greed and selfishness when it comes to valuable land and its resources; it's actually possible. Because, well, humans. What are they, exactly? An entity looking at us from elsewhere would be hard-pressed to come to any other conclusion: we are killers. Plunderers, predators, polluters. The alpha species of a planet we've done untold damage to and continue to destroy for our own selfish appetites.

But the marvellous ice-helmeted land at the end of this Earth arrests this image. It is the continent upon which no human lives permanently; just a handful come and go for the good of science. I visited Antarctica

on a trip resupplying Australia's research bases and it felt as if we were intruders in this wonderland. The scientists treated it as an honour to be working with the singular wildlife.

The animals that greeted us seemed fearless and open and curious because they had no knowledge of what we do; of how dangerous humans are. Animals such as a baby seal with its umbilical cord still attached, snap frozen to its belly, who stared at us with deep, soft brown eyes clear with curiosity and trust. Snow petrels circled our ship, calling and dipping and soaring like angels. Penguins fanned away on the ice, waddling like fast metronomes; on land they peered with voracious curiosity, inching forward, movingly trusting. (We would crawl on our stomachs to observe the wildlife, out of respect, because the animals had never known anything taller than them.)

... Antarctica's preservation in its pristine condition has been a glorious feat of global generosity. It shows that the strange, self-interested species known as human can actually be selfless and bold; it demonstrates the best of our instincts. Let's keep the continent this way – as a tuning fork for how we want to work with other vulnerably wild regions of our beautiful planet in the long term.

NIKKI GEMMELL

A line in the snow

Weekend Australian 6 Nov 2021

* rapacious *aggressively greedy*

** altruistic *unselfish*

Text 1 — Poem

Time Capsule

Sitting on the kitchen shelf
the tea leaves tin
held pride of place
in the running of the house
from breakfast through to dinner.

‘Would you like a cup of tea?’
my mother would question
one and all as a welcome
and a kind of mental setting
for family and guests.

Many lives and times have
passed through that tin,
the ritual of ‘one for each
person and one for the pot’
almost counting out our years
as a family of four children
was suddenly one at home

and I can still see them all
waiting round the table
for the tea to brew
until my father would pour
each cup carefully,
not one drop would he spill.

Into the seventies
the teapot reigned supreme
until suddenly the tea bag
had slipped in like a sniper,
picking off the minutes
of conversation, as if
there was no time to lose.

Now we sift through our parents
belongings to share what can
be sold or used and I grab
the tea leaves tin, thinking this,
of all things drew our family
together, by cup, by spoon.

MIKE GREENACRE

Courtesy of Mike Greenacre

Text 2 — Feature article extract

When I was three years old, I experienced the definition of welcome. My mother's next-door neighbours, Joyce and George, built a gate in our shared garden fence, so that I could visit as often as I wanted. I took this invitation quite far and I began running away daily at bath time in order to sit at their table and share what was often, to my unbridled delight, deep-fat fryer chips ... Alas, we moved and no neighbour has offered the same reception since.

A welcome is an indefinable, nebulous* thing and yet we're all acutely aware of the warmth of it, along with the frost of its opposite. At the wedding of dear Syrian friends, in the garden of friends of theirs who were strangers to us, my husband and I were pulled into the synchronized fray of a joyful, stomping Dabke** dance and it felt like coming home.

Conversely, we've all been somewhere where we have experienced being left out in the cold, on an imaginary doorstep, counting the minutes until we can get back in the car ... there is no excuse for inviting people to come and stay only to meet them with a barren fridge, or dirty sheets and towels.

As a furious, spiky 16-year-old, I went to stay the night with a school friend and her mother plied*** me with welcome, until I softened. She asked me what I wanted to do with my life; she was interested ... In the morning, she brought me breakfast in bed. A croissant with raspberry jam, orange juice and a cafetiere****. And I can conjure the taste of it, 26 years later. They were so generous somehow, these simple acts, in the face of adolescent rebellion and alienation. That lovely mother melted me back down to my original form, just by being kind.

SOPHIE DAHL
The Idea of Welcome

* nebulous	<i>vague, ill-defined</i>
** Dabke	<i>a cultural dance</i>
*** plied	<i>generously gave</i>
**** cafetiere	<i>a coffee pot</i>

Text 3 — Prose extract

One extraordinary time, I felt the strangeness of an unfamiliar terrain ... A strange new pressure of wet pebbles and the tickle of moist sand pushing itself between toes that until then had walked only in dry, dusty earth. As I pushed my feet into that new gritty dampness, the sensation grew upwards and soaked my body in its rough, but velvety, texture. The rubbing of those grains of sand made dry, almost-humming noises that were strange in my ears. I hear that uneasy teeming still, and how its noise became grinding reverberations, discordant* with the rhythm of my goodalu** and of my kujiga***

I was a child and I'd travelled a long way from my home. I was visiting the ocean. They said:

*go walk on the beach,
go swim in the ocean*

and the sand I found there was such a foreign thing. It wasn't anything like the hot dust and gravel of my place ...

The sand on that beach created a million minuscule pressure points under my soles. It tried to swallow my feet and the salt water rushed to carry off small shells and seaweed that caught in my toes. For me, then, sand and shells and seaweed remained just what they were. I struggled to listen or think or feel or see or believe their indecipherable story. There was no story talking to my bones, into my soul ...

At home now, the sharp edges of the gravel biting into my feet remind me to tread wisely and the dust between those hard edges softens and gentles the way into new stories. On that long-ago day, standing on the edge of the ocean, I struggled to take that salty air inside my body and though during the course of my life I have built a friendship with the ocean sand, it is the gravel and dust that are home for me. And, like the becoming of good friendships, I crave that gravel and dust comfort, away from that other place, the place of sand, that makes odd noises in my ears.

DEBRA DANK

from *We Come With This Place*

Debra Dank, *We Come With This Place*, Echo Publishing

* discordant

(of sounds) harsh and jarring

** goodalu and *** kujiga

words from the Gudanji language that indicate concepts about the heart and soul

Text 4 — Memoir extract

It is no great revelation that certain countries or cities can become shorthand for a feeling; that their very name becomes one with an ethos or experience. Hawaii. Thailand. New York. The name of the place automatically conjures a mental picture. So much so that when you say you are going there others immediately intuit what sort of holiday or experience you will have.

Of course, this is not necessarily the case ... Just as we don't know the inner workings of each other's lives, so it is with a foreign country. We have no idea of the way in which it will open up to us, and us to it. And yet we think we do.

Few places on earth, it seems, conjure up more of an emotional response than Italy. It is a land that transcends cliché by simply piling on more of them: afternoon slumbers and wine, church bells and saints, terracotta-coloured villas and washing hanging over balconies, grapevines and pasta, and glittering seas and venerated* old people. It is cobbled thoroughfares and picture-book villages, Pinocchio and families in the piazza, sliced meats and summer fruits, and music on the streets and romance. It is golden light caressing – not just the ancient stone buildings upon which it alights but also those blessed to bask in its rays. Falling in love with a country is like falling in love with a person. You are initially tentative. You start off with a few dates. With a country drive; with dinner. If that goes well, you return for more. Magical outings in which it feels everything is brushed with possibility. Suddenly, your heart is singing. You have never looked better. You feel alive – like your true, unfettered** self. You are open and happy and free. You laugh. You see things differently.

Mostly, falling in love is not so much about the reality of the other person as it is about how they make you feel *about yourself*.

I wasn't looking to fall in love with Italy. I wasn't expecting it. It just happened.

KATE LANGBROEK

Ciao Bella!

With kind permission of Kate Langbroek (Author)

* venerated	<i>respected</i>
** unfettered	<i>unrestricted</i>

Buy Experiences, Not Things

Live in anticipation, gathering stories and memories.

By James Hamblin

In the journal *Psychological Science* last month, Gilovich and Killingsworth, along with Cornell doctoral candidate Amit Kumar, expanded on the current understanding that spending money on experiences “provide[s] more enduring happiness.” ...

Essentially, when you can’t live in a moment, they say, it’s best to live in anticipation of an experience. Experiential purchases like trips, concerts, movies, et cetera, tend to trump material purchases ...

Experiential purchases are also more associated with identity, connection, and social behavior. Looking back on purchases made, experiences make people happier than do possessions. It’s kind of counter to the logic that if you pay for an experience, like a vacation, it will be over and gone; but if you buy a tangible thing, a couch, at least you’ll have it for a long time. Actually most of us have a pretty intense capacity for tolerance, or hedonic adaptation*, where we stop appreciating things to which we’re constantly exposed. Phones, clothes, couches, et cetera, just become background. They deteriorate or become obsolete. It’s the fleetingness of experiential purchases that endears us to them. Either they’re not around long enough to become imperfect, or they are imperfect, but our memories and stories of them get sweet with time. Even a bad experience becomes a good story.

When it rains through a beach vacation, as Kumar put it, “People will say, well, you know, we stayed in and we played board games and it was a great family bonding experience or something.” Even if it was negative in the moment, it becomes positive after the fact. That’s a lot harder to do with material purchases because they’re right there in front of you.

* hedonic adaptation

returning to a stable emotional state after a high or low

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Buy Experiences, Not Things, by James Hamblin, *The New York Times*, April 18, 1989.
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Text 1 — Poem

of glass and wood and water

I am trying to tell you about Venice,
how I felt
waking in a crisp white room
to rain falling softly
in the courtyard
outside my window.

I want to tell you about the light in that room,
about the houseplants and the glass
and the books
in languages I couldn't read
and the bath that didn't work,
how happy I was.

I want to tell you about the colour of Venetian water
and the way the sky and sea
makes everything soft and old,
how the wood groans—
the way nothing is spoken
and everything is sung.

In Venice I walked on wet stone
through a floating cloud.
You weren't there,
so the mist kissed the back of my neck
where you would have.

EMMA BRAZIL

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Text 2 — Prose fiction extract

The flight back to Australia departed late at night, and Jess had left [the house] with hours to spare; partly because she was catching the train [to the airport] and you never know what might happen, but also because, having packed and readied the house for her absence, she'd started to feel like a guest who'd overstayed her welcome and was now being tolerated by a well-mannered host. The train ride had been smooth, and she'd arrived well ahead of time, setting herself up in [a café] near security so she could have a bite to eat before going through the rigmarole^[1]. She preferred it on this side, where travellers and their families were still together. She liked to guess at their relationships and the purpose of travel, the destinations, and the length of time they'd be away.

She had been observing a group of three at a table beside her own and continued to watch them now as they made their way towards the security area. The young woman carrying a backpack was clearly the one leaving, walking faster than the older couple, with an eagerness and energy to her gait^[2]. A few metres out from the door she stopped and they all embraced; some further words were exchanged, the backpack was referenced, and a laugh was shared. Another round of hugs and the girl continued to the door alone. She gave her parents (presumably) a quick wave, flashed them a bright smile, and didn't look back again.

Jess had been that young girl once, twenty years before. She knew about the excitement on the other side of the gate: the first taste of real freedom, the thrilling sense of being, at last, in control of one's own destiny.

KATE MORTON
Homecoming

© Kate Morton

^[1] rigmarole *complicated process*

^[2] gait *walking style*

Text 3 — Nonfiction extract

SMELL IS ONE OF THE LAST REALMS where virtual reality still feels deeply virtual. Recently, I found myself at a theme park riding a VR roller coaster that felt breath-stealingly real. It wasn't just that falling felt like falling and turning felt like turning; I even felt the mist on my face as I flew through ocean spray.

But that water did not *smell* like the ocean. It smelled like this room deodorizer I'd used in high school called "Spring Rain." "Spring Rain" didn't actually smell like spring rain any more than it smelled like the ocean, but the scent did somehow communicate moisture, so I can understand why it had been repurposed as ocean-y. Still, nobody who has ever smelled the salty din of a cresting wave could possibly mistake it for the scent being pumped into that VR experience, and the smell of "Spring Rain" wrenched my mind from its state of joyfully suspended disbelief. Suddenly, I was not on a flying tour of a heaving ocean but instead stuck inside a dark room with a bunch of strangers ...

But I think there's something else at play with smells that try to mimic nature, which is that nothing in the real world ever smells quite like we imagine it should. Actual spring rain, for instance, seems like it ought to smell at once moist and crisp, like the artificial scent does. But in fact, springtime rain smells earthy and acidic.

Humans, meanwhile, smell like the exhalations of the bacteria that colonize us, a fact we go to extraordinary lengths to conceal, not only via soap and perfume, but also in how we collectively imagine the human scent. If you had an artificial intelligence read every novel ever written and then, based on those stories, guess the human odor, the AI would be spectacularly wrong. In our stories, people smell like vanilla, lavender, and sandalwood. The AI would presume we all smell not like the slowly decaying organic matter we are, but instead like newly mown grass and orange blossoms.

JOHN GREEN
The Anthropocene Reviewed

Text 4 — Nonfiction extract

The very first measurement, like the first word or first melody, is lost to time: impossible to localise and difficult even to imagine. Yet it was a hugely significant act: another addition to that nest of primeval^[1] consciousness that grew in the brains of our ancestors hundreds of thousands of years ago, and that would eventually set us apart from the other animals of the plain. For measurement, like speech and play, is the cornerstone of cognition^[2]. It encourages us to pay attention to the boundaries of the world, to notice where the line ends and the scales tip. It requires that we compare one portion of reality to another and describe the differences, creating a scaffold for knowledge ... If we could not measure, then we could not observe the world around us; could not experiment and learn. Measurement allows us to record the past and by doing so uncover patterns that help predict the future. And finally, it is a tool of social cohesion and control, letting us coordinate individual effort into something greater than the sum of its parts. Measurement has not only made the world we live in, it has made us too.

I first began to realise the importance of measurement when writing about the redefinition of the kilogram as a journalist in 2018. I had travelled to Paris for the assignment, and there interviewed scientists who had been working on the project for decades as part of the International Bureau of Weights and Measures, the organisation that oversees the metric system. They explained how, since the eighteenth century, the kilogram had been defined as the weight of a particular lump of metal: an actual physical artefact, kept under lock and key in an underground vault in France. Every weight in the world (even the non-metric ones) could be traced back to this single standard, to *the* kilogram ...

The existence of this hidden world was a revelation. I felt like I had opened the door of my flat one morning only to step out on to the surface of an alien planet, surrounded suddenly by strange trees and the cries of unfamiliar animals. The idea that something as fundamental and commonplace as a unit of measurement was even capable of change was thrilling, and the more I learned, the more questions I had. Why is a kilogram a kilogram, anyway? Why an inch an inch? Who first decided these values and who maintains them now?

As I followed these breadcrumbs, I began to understand what an intellectual feast measurement truly is, what a banquet of historical, scientific, and sociological wonder.

JAMES VINCENT
Beyond Measure

Beyond Measure: The Hidden History of Measurement by James Vincent, Faber and Faber Ltd

^[1] primeval

ancient

^[2] cognition

the mental processing of information

Text 5 — Prose fiction extract

At times these days I think of the way the sun would set on the farmland around our small house in the autumn. A view of the horizon, the whole entire circle of it, if you turned, the sun setting behind you, the sky in front becoming pink and soft, then slightly blue again, as though it could not stop going on in its beauty, then the land closest to the setting sun would get dark, almost black against the orange line of horizon, but if you turn around, the land is still available to the eye with such softness, the few trees, the quiet field of cover crops already turned, and the sky lingering, lingering, then finally dark. As though the soul can be quiet for those moments.

All life amazes me.

ELIZABETH STROUT
My Name is Lucy Barton

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Text 6 — Photograph



Courtesy of Florian Schroeder